



# Desert

Few deserts are completely barren. Most support life of some kind. Highly specialized plants manage to stay alive between occasional rainstorms. These provide food for plant-eating animals, which are preyed upon by a variety of hunters. Many of the small animals that live in hot deserts survive the heat of the day by hiding underground, only emerging at night.

## DRY AS DUST

Deserts are created by cloudless skies and drought. Many are hot, but some are very cold. Even in hot deserts, the nights are often cold because there is no cloud cover to stop heat from escaping into space. Rain does fall, usually as infrequent storms, and some coastal deserts are moistened by oceanic fog. The water that does reach the ground soon evaporates unless it is absorbed by desert plants.



## GREEN SURVIVORS

Some desert plants survive months or even years of drought as seeds, and only spring to life after rainstorms. Others are long-lived shrubs that have very deep or wide root systems for soaking up water, and small leathery leaves to reduce moisture loss. Many, like cacti and this euphorbia, have juicy water-storing flesh, and most are spiny to discourage hungry or thirsty animals from eating them.